

Guide 58 — Veterinary Assistant and Animal Caretaker

Controlled English working master — Version 2.0

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What this work is

Veterinary assistants and animal caretakers support the daily care, safety, cleanliness, observation, and handling of animals in settings such as veterinary clinics, animal hospitals, shelters, kennels, boarding facilities, laboratories, rescue organizations, and other animal-care operations.

This guide focuses on support-level work. It does **not** treat veterinary assistant, veterinary attendant, animal caretaker, veterinary technician/technologist, and veterinarian as interchangeable titles. Duties, credentials, regulated acts, and supervision requirements vary by country, province/state, employer, species, and workplace.

In the United States, O*NET classifies Veterinary Assistants and Laboratory Animal Caretakers as **31-9096.00**. In Canada, a common support-level match is Veterinary Attendant / Animal Care Worker under **NOC 65220**. Colombia has current animal-care training and veterinary-clinic support demand, but professional veterinary practice remains subject to Colombian law and professional registration requirements.

This guide is for career exploration and preparation. Always verify the current requirements for the exact job and jurisdiction before paying for training or performing any clinical task.

What you may do

Depending on the workplace, training, delegation, and local rules, support duties may include:

- feeding and watering animals according to approved instructions;
- cleaning and disinfecting cages, kennels, runs, examination areas, equipment, and work surfaces;
- changing bedding and maintaining orderly animal-care areas;
- observing animal behavior, appetite, elimination, mobility, comfort, and visible condition and reporting changes promptly;
- exercising, grooming, bathing, or transporting animals when trained and authorized;
- helping prepare examination or treatment areas;

- safely restraining or positioning animals using approved methods and appropriate assistance;
- weighing animals or recording non-diagnostic observations;
- stocking supplies and maintaining basic inventory;
- sterilizing or preparing equipment according to workplace procedures;
- assisting with sample preparation or other support tasks under appropriate supervision;
- providing routine postoperative observation or other delegated support when permitted, trained, and supervised;
- assisting veterinarians or veterinary technicians/technologists during approved procedures without independently making clinical decisions;
- scheduling, reception, records, or client-service tasks in some clinics; and
- escalating abnormal signs, injuries, bites, exposure incidents, medication questions, or emergencies to the responsible professional.

O*NET notes that selected tasks such as routine postoperative care, oral or topical medication support, or preparing samples may occur **under the supervision** of veterinary or laboratory animal technologists/technicians, veterinarians, or scientists. That supervision boundary matters.

What this role must not be presented as

A veterinary assistant or animal caretaker is not automatically a veterinarian, veterinary technician, veterinary technologist, nurse, pharmacist, or other licensed professional.

Do not independently:

- diagnose disease or injury;
- prescribe, select, change, or discontinue medication;
- decide anesthesia, sedation, or surgical plans;
- perform surgery;
- represent yourself as a licensed veterinarian or other regulated professional;
- interpret laboratory or diagnostic findings as a final clinical diagnosis;
- make emergency-treatment decisions outside approved training and escalation procedures; or
- perform any restricted act that your jurisdiction, employer, professional regulator, or supervision plan does not permit.

If a task feels clinical, invasive, medication-related, or outside your training, stop and confirm authorization before proceeding.

Work environment and physical demands

Animal-care work can be rewarding, but it can also be physically and emotionally demanding. Workplaces may include veterinary hospitals, clinics, shelters, kennels, laboratories, animal-control facilities, boarding operations, and rescue organizations.

Common demands can include:

- standing and walking for long periods;
- bending, kneeling, reaching, and repeated cleaning;
- lifting or assisting with animals, carriers, food, bedding, and supplies;
- restraining frightened, painful, excited, or aggressive animals;
- exposure to barking, odors, urine, feces, blood, saliva, fur, dander, cleaning chemicals, and medical waste;
- evening, weekend, holiday, or rotating work;
- emotionally difficult cases involving illness, injury, neglect, euthanasia, or distressed owners; and
- fast transitions between animal-care, cleaning, client-service, and administrative duties.

Do not assume that love of animals alone makes the work easy. Reliable attendance, emotional steadiness, safe handling, infection-control discipline, and willingness to clean are central parts of many entry-level roles.

Important safety risks

CDC/NIOSH identifies hazards to veterinary medicine and animal-care workers that include bites, scratches, kicks, crush injuries, strains and sprains from lifting or restraint, zoonotic infections, sharps injuries, allergens, noise, slips, trips, and falls.

Use employer-approved procedures for:

- animal approach, handling, and restraint;
- species-specific behavior and warning signs;
- personal protective equipment;
- hand hygiene and infection prevention;
- cleaning and disinfection;
- isolation precautions;
- sharps handling and disposal;
- medications and hazardous materials;
- animal waste and contaminated materials;
- lifting and team handling;
- bite, scratch, needlestick, splash, allergy, or exposure reporting; and
- emergency escalation.

Never improvise a restraint technique or continue a dangerous hold merely to finish a task. Ask for help, use approved equipment, and follow the veterinarian's or supervisor's direction.

Zoonoses and infection prevention

Zoonoses are infections that can pass between animals and people. Veterinary and animal-care workers can be exposed through bites, scratches, respiratory droplets, feces, urine, saliva, blood, contaminated surfaces, vectors, or other routes depending on the organism and species.

Good practice includes:

- washing hands when required and after relevant animal or environmental contact;
- using appropriate gloves, eye protection, masks, gowns, footwear, or other PPE when indicated;
- following isolation and signage rules;
- cleaning and disinfecting using the correct product, concentration, contact time, and sequence;
- avoiding eating or drinking in contaminated work areas;
- reporting occupational exposures promptly;
- following workplace vaccination or medical-surveillance requirements where applicable; and
- never assuming that an animal that looks healthy carries no infection risk.

Training material and AI tools are not substitutes for workplace infection-control protocols.

Skills employers may value

Employers commonly value:

- safe and calm animal handling;
- careful observation and timely escalation;
- cleanliness and infection-control habits;
- reliability and punctuality;
- empathy without losing professional boundaries;
- accurate recordkeeping;
- clear communication with veterinarians, technicians, coworkers, and clients;
- basic arithmetic and measurement;
- ability to follow written and verbal procedures;
- teamwork during restraint or urgent situations;
- comfort with repetitive cleaning and physical work;

- confidentiality and appropriate handling of client records; and
- willingness to learn employer-specific systems and protocols.

Basic digital skills can help with scheduling, electronic records, inventory systems, email, client communication, and training platforms. No single software product is universal across the occupation.

Education and entry pathways

United States

O*NET identifies the occupation as **31-9096.00**. The U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics states that most veterinary assistants and laboratory animal caretakers have a **high school diploma or equivalent** and learn through **short-term on-the-job training**.

A practical entry sequence is:

1. Review real local postings for veterinary assistant, kennel assistant, animal-care attendant, shelter assistant, laboratory animal caretaker, and related titles.
2. Note recurring requirements for animal handling, cleaning, client service, schedule flexibility, lifting, vaccination, or formal courses.
3. Build safe animal-care fundamentals through reputable training, volunteering, supervised experience, or employer training.
4. Apply for support roles that match your actual experience.
5. Add formal education only when local employers request it or when it supports a clear next step.

Do not pay for an expensive private certificate merely because it uses the words "veterinary assistant." Verify that employers in your area recognize the program.

Canada

Government of Canada Job Bank maps **Veterinary Attendant** and **Animal Care Worker (except farm)** to **NOC 65220**. National requirements state that secondary school is usually required. Depending on the work, training in animal handling, grooming, dog training, animal health, or veterinary-assistant studies may be required.

Job Bank currently records NOC 65220 as **not regulated in Canada** at the national occupational-record level. However, that does not make every veterinary-clinic task unrestricted. Employers, provinces, veterinary regulators, and workplace policies can limit who may perform specific clinical activities.

Canadian title ambiguity deserves special attention. A posting for a veterinary attendant or animal-care worker may be a support role, while a

veterinary technician/technologist role can involve a different education and regulatory pathway. Read the duties and credential requirements, not just the title.

Colombia

SENA Betowa currently lists **Cuidado de animales de compañía**, a **144-hour** in-person complementary course that develops competency in caring for companion animals according to service protocols. Availability, location, admission procedures, and dates can change.

SENA's Agencia Pública de Empleo also shows current employer demand for veterinary-clinic support roles. A verified Auxiliar clínica veterinaria posting includes animal grooming, cleaning and disinfection, behavior monitoring, feeding, and assistance to veterinarians and animal-health technicians.

Employer postings show market demand; they do not define the legal scope of practice.

Under **Ley 576 de 2000**, professional veterinary practice in Colombia is tied to professional registration and matrícula for the professions governed by that law. An assistant or caretaker should therefore never represent support work as independent professional veterinary practice.

Latin America and the Caribbean

Training systems and professional rules vary by country. OIT/Cinterfor maintains a regional network of vocational-training institutions that can help learners identify the appropriate national public or recognized training body.

Use the regional network as a locator, then verify the current national institution, course availability, cost, recognition, and legal scope in the country where you intend to work.

Free-first and low-cost training strategy

A safer sequence before spending money is:

1. Review 15–20 current local job postings and identify the most common requirements.
2. Ask employers whether they provide paid onboarding, animal-handling training, infection-control training, or supervised entry positions.
3. Search public workforce and vocational-training systems before private schools.
4. Compare total tuition, materials, uniforms, transport, vaccines, exams, and other required costs.

5. Verify whether the credential is requested by employers or simply marketed by the school.
6. Ask about refund rules, job-placement claims, externships, insurance, supervision, and whether clinical practice is included.
7. Avoid borrowing heavily for a credential that local employers do not require.

United States funding and training locators

CareerOneStop, sponsored by the U.S. Department of Labor, provides a Local Training Finder and a WIOA-Eligible Training Program Finder. WIOA funding is eligibility-based and varies by state/local workforce system; a listed program does not mean that a particular person is automatically funded.

Use these tools to compare public, community-college, short-term, and eligible workforce options before paying a high-cost private provider.

Canada student aid

Canada Student Grants and Loans can help eligible students pay for approved post-secondary education. Provinces and territories determine which schools and programs qualify, and students generally apply through their province or territory.

For the **2026-27 school year**, the federal full-time student grant can be up to **CAD \$4,200 per year or \$525 per month of study** for eligible students in qualified programs at designated schools, subject to financial-need, jurisdiction, and program rules.

Do not assume that a veterinary-assistant course qualifies. Check the school and program before enrolling.

Colombia and regional public options

Start with current SENA/Betowa offerings and SENA's public employment services. In other Latin American countries, use OIT/Cinterfor's institutional network to identify the appropriate national vocational-training body, then verify the current program directly.

Work-based learning and employer support

Veterinary assistant and animal-care roles often rely heavily on workplace learning. Ask employers about:

- paid onboarding;
- supervised animal-handling training;
- kennel-to-clinic progression;
- cross-training in reception or inventory;

- infection-control and safety instruction;
- reimbursement for approved courses;
- uniforms or PPE support;
- vaccination or occupational-health support where applicable;
- mentorship by experienced staff; and
- advancement pathways toward veterinary technician/technologist education where appropriate.

Get repayment obligations in writing before accepting employer-funded education.

Income and employment outlook

United States — official data

The U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics reports a **median annual wage of USD \$37,320 / \$17.94 per hour** for veterinary assistants and laboratory animal caretakers in **May 2024**.

BLS reports approximately **117,800 jobs in 2024** and projects **9% employment growth from 2024 to 2034**, reaching about **128,100 jobs**, with approximately **22,200 openings per year** on average over the decade.

These are national statistics. Starting wages and local wages vary by employer, region, schedule, setting, experience, and responsibilities.

United States — current non-government estimate

Salary.com reports an **August 1, 2026** U.S. Veterinary Assistant figure of approximately **USD \$35,125 per year / \$17 per hour**, with a stated 25th-75th percentile range of roughly **\$28,302-\$42,369**.

This is a **private market estimate**, not government wage data. Its methodology and title definition differ from BLS, so do not combine the two figures into a single average.

Canada — official data

Government of Canada Job Bank reports national Veterinary Attendant / NOC 65220 wages, updated **November 19, 2025**, of approximately:

- **CAD \$15.00/hour low**
- **CAD \$18.00/hour median**
- **CAD \$25.50/hour high**

Use Job Bank's regional filters because wages vary substantially by province, territory, and local market.

A practical 12-week starting plan

Weeks 1-2: Review local postings. Compare veterinary assistant, kennel assistant, animal-care attendant, shelter, boarding, and reception roles. Record required skills, schedule, lifting, education, vaccines, and experience.

Weeks 3-4: Study animal behavior, safe handling, body-language warning signs, sanitation, disinfectant use, hand hygiene, PPE, zoonoses, and exposure reporting using reputable materials.

Weeks 5-6: Build basic workplace skills: accurate note-taking, simple calculations, inventory, customer service, phone etiquette, confidentiality, and teamwork.

Weeks 7-8: Seek supervised experience through a legitimate employer, shelter, training program, or structured volunteer setting. Do not perform invasive or clinical tasks beyond your authorization.

Weeks 9-10: Prepare a simple evidence portfolio: training certificates, volunteer or work references, examples of cleaning/sanitation procedures learned, safe handling competencies, and documented customer-service skills. Do not include confidential client or animal records.

Weeks 11-12: Apply to realistic entry roles. Ask about paid training, supervision, schedule, physical requirements, PPE, occupational-health expectations, advancement, and any employer-recognized credentials before purchasing additional education.

Building experience without misrepresenting your background

Transferable experience may come from:

- animal shelters or rescue organizations;
- boarding or kennel operations;
- pet-care or grooming support;
- customer service or reception;
- cleaning and sanitation work;
- inventory or stock handling;
- caregiving environments with strong procedure-following expectations;
- farm or animal-handling experience where relevant; or
- supervised volunteer work.

Describe what you actually did. Strong evidence includes safe handling, reliable attendance, cleaning quality, accurate records, calm

communication, inventory accuracy, teamwork, and prompt escalation of problems.

Do not claim veterinary technician, veterinarian, medication-administration, phlebotomy, anesthesia, radiology, surgery, laboratory, or emergency competencies unless you genuinely have the required training, authorization, and experience.

Career progression

Possible next steps include senior veterinary assistant, lead kennel attendant, shelter-care lead, client-service coordinator, laboratory animal caretaker, animal-care supervisor, or specialized employer training.

Some people later pursue formal education as veterinary technicians/technologists or veterinarians. Those are different career pathways with their own education, licensing, registration, and cost considerations. Do not assume that time as an assistant automatically grants a regulated credential.

Using AI responsibly in this work

AI may help with:

- explaining general non-clinical terminology;
- creating study questions;
- practicing interviews;
- organizing non-sensitive notes;
- drafting general supply lists for review; or
- improving administrative writing when employer policy allows it.

AI must **not**:

- diagnose an animal;
- prescribe or choose treatment;
- decide medication dose, route, timing, or changes without approved clinical controls;
- replace veterinarian or regulated-professional judgment;
- decide whether an animal is medically stable or safe to discharge;
- replace emergency or poison-control procedures; or
- override clinic protocols, labels, approved calculations, or supervision requirements.

Verify AI output before use. A confident-looking error about medication, species safety, restraint, infection control, or emergency care can cause serious harm.

Cybersecurity, privacy, and veterinary records

Veterinary workplaces may store owner contact information, payment data, animal medical records, laboratory results, diagnostic images, prescriptions, appointment histories, credentials, and internal business information.

Follow employer rules for:

- passwords and multifactor authentication;
- role-based access;
- phishing and suspicious attachments;
- approved messaging and file-sharing;
- payment-card handling;
- medical-record access;
- client identity and contact information;
- diagnostic images and laboratory results;
- removable media and shared workstations;
- incident reporting; and
- use of public AI services.

Do not paste client identity data, payment details, medical records, diagnostic images, prescriptions, credentials, proprietary clinic protocols, or internal incidents into a public AI service unless the employer has explicitly approved that use and required safeguards are in place.

Avoid scams and weak training offers

Be cautious when a school, recruiter, clinic, or training seller:

- guarantees a job or specific salary;
- claims a private certificate is legally mandatory without regulator or government evidence;
- pressures you to pay immediately;
- hides total tuition, supplies, vaccine, insurance, externship, or exam costs;
- will not explain whether employers recognize the credential;
- promises that a short course makes you a veterinarian or veterinary technician;
- asks you to pay for a job offer using gift cards, cryptocurrency, wire transfer, or unusual methods; or
- requests sensitive identity or banking information before you have independently verified the organization.

Check the employer, school, government training system, and professional regulator where relevant before paying.

When to pause before spending money

Pause before enrollment when:

- employers in your area provide on-the-job training;
- local postings do not request the credential;
- the provider cannot state the full cost in writing;
- the program's clinical practice or supervision is unclear;
- the school implies that support training grants licensed veterinary authority;
- public, workforce, employer, or low-cost options may cover the same skills;
- you have not checked whether the program qualifies for promised funding; or
- borrowing would create debt that is difficult to repay on realistic entry-level wages.

Current sources

Official/public sources:

- O*NET OnLine — Veterinary Assistants and Laboratory Animal Caretakers, 31-9096.00: [Source link](#)
- U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics — Veterinary Assistants and Laboratory Animal Caretakers: [Source link](#)
- CareerOneStop — Find Training: [Source link](#)
- CareerOneStop — WIOA-Eligible Training Program Finder: [Source link](#)
- Government of Canada Job Bank — Veterinary Attendant requirements, NOC 65220: [Source link](#)
- Government of Canada Job Bank — Veterinary Attendant wages, NOC 65220: [Source link](#)
- Government of Canada — Canada Student Grants and Loans: [Source link](#)
- Government of Canada — How student-aid funding works: [Source link](#)
- Government of Canada — Full-Time Student Grant: [Source link](#)
- SENA Betowa — Cuidado de animales de compañía: [Source link](#)
- SENA Agencia Pública de Empleo — Auxiliar clínica veterinaria example: [Source link](#)
- Función Pública — Ley 576 de 2000: [Source link](#)
- OIT/Cinterfor — Red institucional: [Source link](#)
- OIT/Cinterfor — Formación profesional data by country: <https://www.oitcinterfor.org/statsfp/paises>

- CDC/NIOSH — Hazards to Veterinary Medicine and Animal Care Workers: [Source link](#)
- CDC/NIOSH — Veterinary Safety and Health Hazard Prevention and Control: [Source link](#)
- CDC — Veterinary Resources / Healthy Pets, Healthy People: [Source link](#)

Supplementary non-government salary source:

- Salary.com — Veterinary Assistant Salary, August 1, 2026: [Source link](#)

Source and review note

This guide uses current-source research recorded on August 20, 2026. Wages, course availability, student aid, employer requirements, regulated acts, professional rules, and local hiring conditions can change. Recheck official sources and current job postings before acting.

This controlled revision was produced with AI assistance and auditable source review. It does **not** claim independent human certification, professional accreditation, certified translation, accessibility certification, legal review, financial advice, veterinary diagnosis, or guaranteed employment outcomes.